

SECOND COMING Filmmaker Rima Das; (below) a still from *Village Rockstars 2*



CINEMA

SONG OF THE ROAD

Rima Das's sequel to *Village Rockstars* had its world premiere at the Busan International Film Festival, the only Indian film in competition

When Rima Das was making *Village Rockstars* (2017), her National Award–winning second film, she had no idea that it would warrant a sequel seven years later. That thought crossed her mind only after she watched it on the big screen, witnessed the unanimous acclaim that it received from critics, and the unending curiosity that audiences had about the characters. The filmmaker remembers replaying the film's final moment—where 10-year-old Dhunu (Bhanita Das) receives a guitar from her mother—in her head multiple times. "In the film, when Dhunu was playing the guitar for the first time, it wasn't only a character. It was also happening in real life," Das tells INDIA TODAY. "It felt like a beginning, rather than an ending."

A year later, during the production of her third film *Bulbul Can Sing* (2018), Das bought a guitar for Bhanita, her young heroine, real life imitating the reel. Now, six years later, she is ready with *Village Rockstars 2*, which had its world premiere at the Busan International Film Festival this month, the only Indian film in competition. "*Village Rockstars* is very special to me—not only as a film, but also in terms of how it transformed my understanding of my roots and how I connected to it," says Das. *Village Rockstars 2*, according to her, is infused with a similar spirit, a coming-of-age drama that examines the relationship that 17-year-old Dhunu forges with music amid the changing landscape of her village.

RIMA DAS, who is a self-taught filmmaker, is obsessive about retaining her independence and visual style as a storyteller

In the last decade, the Hindi film industry has bastardised the idea of sequels and franchises in a bid for box-office relevancy, often sacrificing the integrity that made a film distinctive in the first place. Das was aware of the challenges of revisiting her "most popular and talked-about film". The filmmaker, who also wrote, shot, edited, and produced *Village Rockstars 2*, was certain that she didn't want to lose the authenticity and purity that had made the film's first part such a widely feted phenomenon. So, she first chose to gauge Bhanita's interest in learning to play the guitar before embarking on the project. "Anyone can dance and sing in a film. But when you have a film following a character playing an instrument, the stakes are different. It's harder to cheat."

Das, who is a self-taught filmmaker, is obsessive about retaining her independence and visual style as a storyteller. All her projects are self-funded and her cinema is known to focus more on mood, feeling and rhythm than on plot or spectacle. "Generally, I just go and shoot my films. My starting point is my intuition." In the seven-year period between these two films, Das admits that her characteristic eye has undergone an evolution, evident in the broader emotional range and tighter edit of *Village Rockstars 2*. Still, she sees the difference as a natural progression. "If I am making a film that is set in Mumbai, it will look different from something I'm making in Assam. In many ways, I feel like water." ■

-Poulomi Das